

Chapter 135_1 - Domineering

Upon hearing these words, everyone else looked at each other.

"This..." the observing Master Feiguang¹ stroked his bald head.

"We have always respected the Divine Venerable. We don't know how the Divine Venerable was bewitched by demons to protect her so, but everything must consider the greater good. I can only be disrespectful!" Hua Hong² slowly drew out a thousand-mechanism umbrella made of steel, giving it a light shake. The countless bells hanging from the umbrella's edge rang with soul-bewildering sounds.

He exchanged a glance with Gongsun Mo³, and suddenly they both soared into the air together. The thousand-mechanism umbrella spun and shot out countless arrows, while Gongsun Mo once again wielded his brush frantically, the formed ink traces carrying fierce winds as they attacked the two women one by one.

Chu Qingqiu showed no fear. She suddenly stepped on the wind and rose up, the white silk behind her turning into afterimages, easily breaking their moves. Then her white bone staff chopped down vertically, and while the frost separated the two men, it instantly froze the surroundings three feet deep.

Ning Fuyi squinted her eyes in the wind. Through the gaps in her eyelashes, Chu Qingqiu's figure was somewhat blurred, yet beneath that frost, she suddenly seemed to glimpse incomparable spring beauty.

The goddess who was once untouchable now stood firmly by her side without wavering.

How could she have any more dissatisfaction?

Taking advantage of her distraction, Li Hanxi⁴ on the side suddenly conjured another long whip. The whip with hanging flowers cracked the air crisply as it chopped toward her head. However, this strike that should have been certain to hit stopped mid-air just as it was about to strike Ning Fuyi.

Li Hanxi mobilized all her immortal power, frowning as she pressed the whip downward, trying to break through the air's envelope. However, to her panic, no matter how hard she exerted herself, the whip remained motionless.

The woman in front of her, who seemed to have never paid attention to her, suddenly turned around and looked at her steadily.

Li Hanxi's hair stood on end. At the same time, the airflow wrapping the long whip suddenly burst outward in all directions, and her whip once again shattered into pieces.

Along with Li Hanxi's and the surrounding people's cries of alarm, the coffered ceiling⁵ painted with various colors suddenly cracked down the middle with a snap. The crack spread rapidly, and finally the entire ceiling collapsed with a thunderous crash.

Accompanied by the chaos of earth-shaking tremors, a heavenly thunder wrapped in sparks rushed down. The several observers could no longer refrain from acting, hurriedly summoning their immortal power to weave a colorful net, preventing Feihua Tower from becoming ruins.

The heavenly thunder exploded into flying sparks in mid-air. Everything else in the wine tower suffered, with vermilion railings bursting into roaring flames and cloud-like brocade instantly turning to ash.

"What are you standing there for? Quickly set up barriers!" Hua Hong, still engaged in fierce battle, angrily scolded toward the door. The observing disciples hurriedly stood up, rushing out in a flustered stream.

"Ning Fuyi, what demonic arts have you practiced to possess such cultivation in such a short time!" Li Hanxi covered her chest, dumbfounded. Though she had witnessed Ning Fuyi taking action at Liugen Huayan Island⁶ last time, Ning Fuyi hadn't fully exposed her immortal power then, so everyone hadn't taken it seriously.

"That heavenly thunder just now came so fiercely, it still has my heart pounding," said Jin Yan⁷, the head of the Tianshan Jin family, with lingering fear. She looked at Chu Qingqiu who was still entangled with the two men, saying with reluctance, "Sect Leader Hua, the Divine Venerable has just returned from the dead. Why don't we stop fighting and discuss this further!"

"Yes, the Divine Venerable has always cared for all living beings. How could she deliberately shield demons? To fight like this over a disagreement is inappropriate both emotionally and logically!" Master Feiguang chanted "Amitabha" and stepped forward to intervene.

Hua Hong and Gongsun Mo should have had the upper hand against Chu Qingqiu, but hearing everyone's words disrupted their concentration, and they nearly had their arms cut off by the cold light.

In just this moment of distraction, Ning Fuyi's figure also appeared beside Chu Qingqiu. Thus lightning and frost merged into blades, striking their chests respectively. Two streams of blood spurted forth, and when everyone looked again, the two men had already retreated repeatedly, staggering to steady themselves.

While opposite them, the black and white figures landed gracefully, standing side by side.

The tower immediately fell silent, with only the unextinguished flames crackling. Hua Hong's expression appeared unchanged, but beneath his fine robes he was already gasping for breath. His gaze swept over Chu Qingqiu and Ning Fuyi, his eyes churning with changing emotions.

He had indeed underestimated them. Originally thinking that Chu Qingqiu, having returned from the dead, shouldn't have much cultivation, he now discovered through fighting that this person's cultivation speed was terrifying - in just a few months, her power had deepened immeasurably.

As for Ning Fuyi, even more so. Ordinary people cultivating for thirty years could at most cross one or two realms, and going further required being among the most talented geniuses. Ning Fuyi had previously worn the name of waste, and he thought her cultivation was nothing special, but now it greatly exceeded his expectations.

Moreover, she was currently only using immortal power and hadn't mobilized demonic energy. If she added demonic energy, probably everyone present combined would have difficulty subduing her.

It seemed that trying to forcibly subdue this demon would be difficult to accomplish!

After this silence for a while, he suddenly dimmed the cold light in his eyes again, slowly brushing dust from his sleeves and signaling Gongsun Mo to stop.

Gongsun Mo exhaled a long breath and fiercely put away his writing brush.

"It seems the Divine Venerable is determined to protect the demon clan," Hua Hong smiled as he put away his thousand-mechanism umbrella. "I really don't understand why the Divine Venerable, who has always cared for all living beings, has become like this."

"She has never harmed anyone. My protecting her is just protecting her - it has nothing to do with all living beings," Chu Qingqiu said as she lowered her white bone staff.

"I know that Ning Fuyi was once a disciple of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate and is the daughter of Condensing Heaven Sect Leader. Your protective feelings toward her are understandable, but you cannot forget the justice in your heart because of this," Hua Hong tried to appeal to emotion.

"Justice?" Chu Qingqiu stood with hands behind her back. "This venerable has never had the justice of killing innocents or wronging good people. I once blindly despised demons, believing they deserved death, but later I discovered I was wrong. Some who call themselves immortals but oppress the weak are more deserving of death than demons who are born bearing demonic energy!"

As she spoke with cold brows raised high, Hua Hong's smile froze on his face.

"Based solely on incomplete fragments of words, you can judge that Ning Fuyi is an evil demon who commits all manner of crimes, not knowing that those who speak such words are the truly petty people, never mentioning a word about Ning Fuyi saving her life. Could it be that your Feihua Sect⁸ only teaches mechanical arts but never teaches how to be an upright person!" Chu Qingqiu spoke each word clearly, until Hua Feiwu⁹ hung her head so low it nearly touched her chest, not daring to raise her eyes.

Everyone looked toward Hua Feiwu, while Ning Fuyi looked at Chu Qingqiu.

Chu Qingqiu wasn't incapable of scolding people - it's just that most of the time she would coldly disparage with a single sentence, never wasting words. But now she seemed truly angry, just rattling off scolding until people were struck speechless.

Ning Fuyi had originally wanted to say something, but now couldn't get a word in edgewise. However, the smile on her lips grew deeper, her gaze burning as she watched Chu Qingqiu's anger-filled profile.

"Saved his life?" Jin Yan stepped forward to pull over Hua Feiwu, looking up at his expression before saying softly, "Divine Venerable, could you elaborate a bit more?"

"That would have to be asked of Sect Leader Hua's good son," Chu Qingqiu looked toward Hua Feiwu.

Hua Feiwu, being looked at by her, dared even less to raise his head. Under everyone's gaze, he stammered for a long time before squeezing out a sentence: "This matter is true."

Hua Hong's brow furrowed tightly, while the others exchanged glances and whispered among themselves.

"Everyone knows that Xuanyuan Kingdom was long buried beneath wind and sand. Since you manage the Chuwei Hall¹⁰, what business did you have going there?" Hua Hong turned to question Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi, who hadn't spoken, now turned her neck and smiled: "I am good friends with Young Master Jiang Li of the Jiang family. Hearing she had disappeared, I went to find her. What's wrong with that? Unfortunately, your son's cultivation was insufficient, and he was captured by those giant serpents to fill their furnace. If I hadn't single-handedly broken into those black snakes' territory and pulled him out from the snake's tail, he would probably have turned to ashes long ago. Where would he have the chance to speak nonsense in front of me?"

"As for whether my saving him is true or false, Old Lady Jiang shouldn't lie," Ning Fuyi looked toward Jiang Wuying¹¹ sitting in the distance, who nodded without denial.

Hua Hong was left speechless. He glared darkly at Hua Feiwu, but the other party didn't dare raise his head for a moment, making him even more frustrated at his failure to meet expectations.

"Fine, even if you saved my son's life - this great kindness I, Hua, will remember deeply in my heart. But that demonic energy still hasn't been explained," Hua Hong turned to say.

"Unable to distinguish between demonic energy and miasma¹² - I'm afraid only your son, such a wastrel cultivator, could manage such a thing," Ning Fuyi tilted her head.

"Miasma?" Hua Hong asked in confusion. He turned back to look at Hua Feiwu, lowering his voice: "What miasma?"

Hua Feiwu immediately panicked. Only then did he raise his head, pointing at Ning Fuyi and saying: "Don't you dare speak nonsense. That day it was clearly demonic energy - I saw it clearly and couldn't be wrong!"

"That day Xuanyuan Kingdom was filled with miasma. To save Sect Leader Tang who was trapped in the miasma, I returned to Xuanyuan Kingdom and was accidentally severely injured by the miasma, nearly having my mind devoured. Fortunately, everyone present helped me expel the miasma, and only then did I regain consciousness," Ning Fuyi spoke confidently. "I don't know how it became demonic energy in your son's mouth."

"If you really don't believe me, then Sect Leader Tang, as the head of the six sects, surely wouldn't lie for an unknown person like me, would he?"

Seeing her speak so confidently, even Gongsun Mo, who had been fierce and menacing just moments before, somewhat lost his momentum. He picked up his fan and waved it again, saying in a low voice: "Hearing her speak with such certainty, why don't we send someone to invite Sect Leader Tang and ask for clarification?"

"Father, Uncle Gongsun, I absolutely didn't lie - she's the one deceiving people!" Hua Feiwu found it hard to defend himself, his face flushed red with urgency. Suddenly remembering something, he shouted loudly: "Elder brother! Elder brother was there that day too. He definitely wouldn't favor demons!"

Hearing this, Gongsun Mo snapped his fan shut with a pop and pointed: "Right, that child Hua Feihua¹³ has a steady and reliable character. Why not call him to clarify this matter?"

Hua Hong's expression was complex as he waved his hand to command: "Someone, please invite the Young Sect Leader."

After a long while, the door behind them opened again, and a thin man in light blue brocade robes walked in. He glanced at the chaotic wine tower, carefully avoiding the flames as he walked to everyone and bowed.

Ning Fuyi saw that the wound on the back of his hand was still clear. Though it had been bandaged, black edges were still visible - clearly not an ordinary wound.

Her heart lifted slightly. Though Jiuying had just transmitted words through their contract telling her to just firmly insist she hadn't become a demon, she still didn't know this person's character and couldn't help worrying.

"Father," Hua Feihua said in a deep voice.

"You wouldn't speak up when asked earlier, but surely you can speak now in front of everyone. What Ning Fuyi used to injure you - was it demonic energy or not?" Hua Hong stared at him intently.

Hua Feihua's hand, burned by demonic energy, trembled for an instant. He unconsciously looked up at Hua Feiwu, then at Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu standing in the center.

"It was..." he said slowly. Just as Hua Feiwu sighed in relief, he suddenly turned his head, his voice growing louder.

"It was miasma."

Upon hearing this, the others all opened their mouths: "It really was miasma. Could it be that someone was truly wronged?"

"These two brothers both witnessed it personally - why do their words differ?"

Hearing this, Hua Feiwu flew into a rage, suddenly rushing forward to grab Hua Feihua's collar: "It was clearly demonic energy - you said so yourself! Why are you lying!"

But Hua Feihua didn't resist, only turning his face slightly aside, letting his younger brother push and pummel him without making a sound. Finally, Hua Hong couldn't stand it anymore and angrily shouted "Enough!", waving his hand to separate the two.

"Stop this both of you! Hua Feiwu, you've caused all the elders to accompany your nonsense by distorting the truth. Quickly apologize to everyone!"

Hua Hong had completely lost face. He lifted his leg and kicked Hua Feiwu in the back of the knee, sending him crashing to the ground. However, Hua Feiwu refused to admit his error, veins bulging on his forehead as he shouted loudly that he hadn't lied. Finally, Hua Hong couldn't bear it anymore and simply ordered people to drag him away. Only then did the tower return to quiet.

Hua Hong was so angry that sweat soaked his hair. He slowly turned around, and after a long while managed to force out a smile: "It was my poor teaching that wrongly accused the Hall Master and nearly harmed the Divine Venerable."

Chu Qingqiu took in everything that happened, her expression unchanged.

"No need for apologies. I'm magnanimous and won't stoop to your level," Ning Fuyi said with crossed arms, satisfied to see Hua Hong's face beginning to turn green.

"However," she changed her tone and suddenly became serious, "there were many events that day. You shouldn't just listen to these trivial matters, but should properly hear about the Infinite Ghost Fire."

"Infinite Ghost Fire?" Someone repeated the name, seemingly unaware of what this was, but more people's faces immediately darkened.

Gongsun Mo forgot to wave his fan, suddenly stepping forward two paces and crying out in alarm: "How do you know about the Infinite Ghost Fire?"

"I saw it with my own eyes, so naturally I know," Ning Fuyi said.

Then she recounted everything she had seen on her journey to Xuanyuan Kingdom, only concealing the parts about Jiang Li and Black Scales to avoid bringing trouble to Jiang Li.

After finishing, the entire venue fell silent.

"Ning Fuyi, you mustn't speak carelessly. Penglai is the head of the immortal realm - how could they use human lives to refine such demonic objects?" Li Hanxi spoke up.

"Head of the immortal realm? The head of the immortal realm that has been in seclusion for two thousand years, ignoring the living beings of the Six Realms?" Ning Fuyi scoffed. "That day at Liugen Huayan Island, I gave each of you papers that I'm sure you've all verified."

"Whether there's something suspicious or not, please judge for yourselves. As for whether what I said is true or false, I'm not the only one present who was there. That fire was extinguished by Sect Leader Tang - he should know better than I do."

She paused, then suddenly stepped forward, her words becoming more serious.

"I, Ning Fuyi, have never thought of opposing the immortal sects. I can honestly say that in this lifetime I have never done anything to harm others, let alone destroy the world. I only wish for my relatives and friends to live well."

"I only wish for wind in spring and snow in summer¹⁴, to live peacefully in a corner with those I love, through the four seasons' cycle, until our hair turns white." As she spoke, she looked at Chu Qingqiu. Chu Qingqiu didn't avoid her gaze but extended her hand toward her.

Ning Fuyi felt a warm current surge through her heart. She raised her hand and interlocked fingers with her, then heard gasps from around them. Some people immediately understood, some were furious, and some were still confused about the situation.

"What are you laughing at?" Master Feiguang, with his bald head, asked Jin Yan beside him who was smiling.

"I laugh when I want to laugh," Jin Yan kept staring at his shiny scalp, now reaching out to touch it and rubbing her hands together with satisfaction.

"Eh, Amitabha, sinful..." Master Feiguang quickly covered his bald head and moved to the other side.

Most of the others showed expressions of astonishment. Only Li Hanxi sadly raised her hand, actually shedding a tear of heartbreak. Hua Hong and Gongsun Mo, two old-fashioned men, had increasingly iron-blue faces, but considering the two women, neither dared say more.

"You are all outstanding figures of the immortal realm and surely don't wish for these living beings to suffer. Now I have said all I can. What should be done need not be said further," Ning Fuyi glanced at them. "Farewell."

With that, she pulled Chu Qingqiu toward the door. The disciples at the entrance didn't dare block them anymore, so they swaggered across the threshold and walked into the gentle breeze of late spring outside.

Because of the barrier's protection, the street remained peaceful, with common people coming and going hurriedly, no one knowing what had transpired in the luxurious wine tower before them.

Ning Fuyi swung their joined hands: "Divine Venerable, I've revealed our relationship like this without consulting you first. Do you blame me for not discussing it with you, for tarnishing your pure reputation?"

"Of course not," Chu Qingqiu said, closing her eyes toward the sunlight, her vision filled with warm orange-red.

"Actually, if it weren't for that Li Hanxi being there, I wouldn't have been so impulsive. But I just couldn't bear to let her look at you with those eyes," Ning Fuyi said openly, turning her head as her index finger traced across Chu Qingqiu's smooth face, stopping at her chin.

"No one is allowed to covet you," Ning Fuyi's pupils suddenly deepened several shades as she gazed into those peach blossom eyes currently full of tenderness.

"So domineering?" Chu Qingqiu's eyes moved slightly as she smiled.

"Yes," Ning Fuyi moved closer to her, not caring about the strange looks from passersby.

Chu Qingqiu rarely let her smile linger this long, but she still wasn't used to the probing gazes of passing pedestrians. She raised her white bone staff and pressed it against Ning Fuyi's waist, slowly pushing her away: "Enough."

"Where do you want to go now? Find them, or seek out Penglai?" Chu Qingqiu asked, appearing ready to follow her completely.

"You'll really listen to me?" The playful tone in Ning Fuyi's voice disappeared, her expression becoming more serious as she grasped her fingers with both hands.

"I want to find a quiet place," she said. "Chu Qingqiu, you're no longer the Divine Venerable with limitless cultivation from before. You struggled dealing with Hua Hong and Gongsun Mo just now."

"I'm also not the Heaven-Slaying God Demon from my previous life. No matter how much I cultivate, I can't turn the tide alone. Those matters of saving all living beings shouldn't be yours to bear alone."

"Right now I just want to be with you, to find a secluded place to stay together, even if just for a while," Ning Fuyi said carefully.

She had expected Chu Qingqiu to refuse, to criticize her for not understanding the bigger picture and ignoring all living beings.

But Chu Qingqiu didn't. She just looked at Ning Fuyi quietly for a moment: "Fine. Since I said I'd listen to you, then I'll listen to you."

Ning Fuyi was immediately overjoyed, beaming: "Really? You're willing?"

"Shiqi¹⁵ left without saying goodbye and returned to Penglai. Sect Leader Tang is recovering from his injuries. Only Jiuying, Qiuyi¹⁶, Wenzhu¹⁷, and Divine Physician Jiang¹⁸ are nearby. I'll notify them now and have them come find us at Purple Cloud Peak."

"Shall we return to Purple Cloud Peak?" Ning Fuyi could barely contain her joy as she hugged Chu Qingqiu.

Chu Qingqiu was shaken back and forth until her hair was disheveled, so she clicked her tongue in displeasure. Ning Fuyi quickly released her hands and stood with them behind her back.

Chu Qingqiu reached out to pinch her nose, turning the tip red before smiling: "Let's go."

As soon as White Lin returned to Purple Cloud Peak, it ran wild with joy, kicking up its hooves and bounding off to who knows where. Ning Fuyi pulled Chu Qingqiu along to clean the stone hall - though calling it cleaning was really just a wave of the hand.

"I remember being quite afraid of this cold, desolate place before, always feeling it had no human warmth at all. Now I actually find this place quite cozy with its tables, chairs, and beds," Ning Fuyi said as she wandered around the spacious stone hall with her hands behind her back.

Chu Qingqiu sat on a stone chair, picked up a cup of tea, and pointed with her slender finger: "You used to like crouching in that spot to cry. I don't know what attracted you to that place."

She was pointing to a corner of the stone hall where several stones of different sizes were scattered as decoration.

"Would you like to see what's there?" Ning Fuyi suddenly smiled, stepping backward as she spoke.

Chu Qingqiu glanced at her sideways but finally couldn't resist her curiosity. She got up with her tea and walked slowly to the corner, brushing aside those stones with her lowered head. Thus, a row of densely packed carved characters appeared clearly on the wall corner.

"Chu Qingqiu, annoying pest, big turtle..." she read.

Chu Qingqiu's mouth corners drooped. She immediately drew out her white bone staff and turned to strike Ning Fuyi on the head. However, just as she turned around, the stone hall before her suddenly lit up with red candles, enveloped in a romantic glow.

Footnotes:

1. **飞光禅师 (Master Feiguang)** - A Buddhist monk character, literally "Flying Light Zen Master."
2. **花鸿 (Hua Hong)** - Sect Leader of Feihua Sect, literally "Flower Rainbow."
3. **公孙墨 (Gongsun Mo)** - An elder character, literally "Grandson Ink."
4. **李菡萏 (Li Hanxi)** - A character whose name contains lotus-related characters.
5. **藻井 (Coffered ceiling)** - An ornately decorated ceiling with recessed panels, common in Chinese architecture.
6. **六根华严岛 (Liugen Huayan Island)** - A location mentioned earlier in the story.
7. **金雁 (Jin Yan)** - Head of the Tianshan Jin family, literally "Golden Goose."
8. **飞花教 (Feihua Sect)** - The sect led by Hua Hong, literally "Flying Flower Sect."
9. **花非雾 (Hua Feiwu)** - Hua Hong's younger son.
10. **懋畏堂 (Chuwei Hall)** - An organization or building name.
11. **江无影 (Jiang Wuying)** - An elder from the Jiang family, literally "Jiang No-Shadow."
12. **瘴气 (Miasma)** - Noxious vapors or unhealthy air, different from demonic energy.
13. **花非花 (Hua Feihua)** - Hua Hong's elder son, literally "Flower Not-Flower."
14. **春有风夏有雪 (Wind in spring and snow in summer)** - An impossible or rare natural phenomenon, expressing a wish for something extraordinary and beautiful.
15. **拾七 (Shiqi)** - Baili Shiqi, a character from Penglai.
16. **秋亦 (Qiuyi)** - Chu Qingqiu's disciple.
17. **文竹 (Wenzhu)** - Liu Wenzhu, a friend of Ning Fuyi.
18. **江医仙 (Divine Physician Jiang)** - Jiang Li, a physician character.